

The Story We Are Telling

Walkthrough of our six dashboard visualisations and the narrative they support.

Our question

How do NHS elective care waiting times vary across England's regions? Is this a funding and staffing issue, or is something else driving these disparities?

The narrative arc

Decade of national failure (Vis 1). Regional disparity, static and over time (Vis 2 and 3). Staffing has actually grown (Vis 4). The real driver is demand which has more than doubled and is only just recovering (Vis 5). Find your trust (Vis 6).

Vis 1 - National trend line

The 18-week target hasn't been met since 2017. The decline started before COVID.

- Target last met June 2017 (orange dashed line)
- Pre-COVID decline already visible from ~93% to ~85%
- Sharp drop when COVID red band starts
- Plateau at ~65% currently. 27 points below target.

Vis 2 - Regional divergence heatmap

Pre-COVID every region was uniform green. After 2020 they fanned out. Same shock, different outcomes.

- The uniform green wall pre-2020
- From 2020 onwards rows fan out into oranges and reds
- East of England deepest red. North East and Yorkshire holds best.

Vis 3 - Animated geographic map

Watch the postcode lottery emerge live. Country starts uniformly green. By 2026 the south-east is visibly worse.

- Press play. Don't talk over the first run, let it speak.
- Bubble sizes grow visibly as waiting lists balloon
- One bubble per real NHS trust, plotted at its postcode

Vis 4 - Staffing growth bars

The obvious assumption: we're underfunded and understaffed. The data says no - we've grown the workforce by over a third.

- Bars get taller every year. No decline anywhere.
- From ~1.0M to ~1.4M FTE. About 35% growth over the decade.
- If staff are up by a third, why is performance halved? Pivot to next chart.

Vis 5 - Demand explosion area chart

It isn't staffing. It's demand. The waiting list more than doubled - it grew over four times faster than the workforce.

- From 3M in 2015 to 7.3M peak in August 2023. Almost 8 million people.
- The slight dip on the right - we are recovering, just slowly.
- Compare this 100%+ rise to the 35% staffing rise. That's the gap.
- Closing line: 'It is not staffing. It is demand. And recovery has only just started.'

Vis 6 - Searchable trust table

Make it personal. Patients can search for their own trust and see what they're walking into.

- Demonstrate the search by typing a well-known trust name
- Best at top is dramatically different from worst at bottom
- Close the presentation here. The patient has been heard.

Closing line

"It is not staffing. It is demand. And recovery has only just started."